and reassuring step" towards nuclear disarmament and reduce their stockpiles. This appeal was reiterated in the joint statement issued by the leaders of the six countries at the end of the meeting.

He also had a vision of improving relations with the Soviet Union, the United States and China. Simultaneously, he gave priority to the betterment of relations with the neighbours, especially Pakistan and Sri Lanka. With the neighbours he was bent on pursuing a bilateral foreign policy based on the spirit of peace, friendship and cooperation, non-interference and also intended to work towards the concept of common regional development in South Asia.

Rajiv Gandhi realized the complexities in the relation between the United States and India. Thus, he took an early opportunity to visit the United States in June 1985 and struck a rapport with President Ronald Reagan. He, however, took the opportunity and pointed out the lurking dangers of a rapidly nuclearizing Pakistan. The initial bonhomie was, however, over by the time he visited the United States in October 1985, coinciding with the 40th Anniversary of the United Nations, as the American desire of dilution of Indo–Soviet relationship was never materialized. Despite such irritants, Indo–US relationship did not reach a nadir and there was considerable interchange in various fields like political, economic, cultural and social.

Rajiv Gandhi adopted caution while cultivating yet protecting, India's ties with the Soviet Union. This bilateral tie served the interests of both the sides. It not only enabled India to fend off a number of hostile challenges that came from China, Pakistan and from the West in the form of support to Pakistan but also helped Soviet Union to expand its ties with non-aligned countries in the face of continuous attempts of the West to Isolate it form world politics. Rajiv Gandhi went on his first visit to Moscow from 21 to 26 May 1985 which resulted in fruitful interactions in strategic as well as economic fields. The return visit by the Soviet President Mikhail Gorbachev to India in November 1986 was a landmark in India's relation with the Soviet Union. New agreements were signed between India and the Soviet Union in the field of economic and technical cooperation.

Rajiv Gandhi was successful in melting the ice in Indo–China